

A Guide to Funding Recreation and Conservation Projects

A Basic Guide for Government Officials,
Non-Profit Organizations, and Citizens



Department of Conservation and Natural Resources
Bureau of Recreation and Conservation



The Bureau's Mission Statement

To be a leader in establishing community
conservation partnerships for
advancing the greening of Pennsylvania,
for protecting the Commonwealth's
natural and heritage resources,
and for providing recreational
opportunities for all Pennsylvanians
and visitors to enjoy

July, 2003-Second Edition



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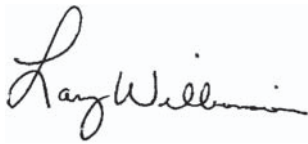
Designed by Sherri Clukey, DCNR

Dear Grant Applicants:

The Bureau of Recreation and Conservation is pleased to provide this grants booklet to assist our applicants in their understanding of the grant process.

Our intent is to edit and update this grants booklet as necessary to maintain current and helpful information. To help us do that, we will need feedback and input from you. Please take a few minutes to complete the questionnaire on page 10 and return it to DCNR, Bureau of Recreation and Conservation, Rachel Carson State Office Building, P.O. Box 8475, Harrisburg, Pa. 17105-8475.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading "Larry Williamson". The signature is written in a cursive style with a large initial "L" and a long horizontal stroke at the end.

Larry Williamson, Director
Bureau of Recreation and Conservation

PURPOSE

Across Pennsylvania, communities of all sizes are preserving open space, developing recreation areas and facilities, improving rivers and streams, and connecting recreation and conservation areas with greenways and trails. Meeting growing recreational demands, improving community and regional environments, and promoting the wise use of land and water are essential to sustaining a high quality of life for all Pennsylvanians.

Providing for community recreation and conservation needs requires investments in land, site development, facility construction, and operation and maintenance. Where recreation and conservation needs have yet to be identified and assessed, investments in feasibility studies and comprehensive plans are often necessary. For many municipalities that have parks and other recreation facilities, professional staff and the resources to plan and implement recreation programs are needed. However, in times when elected officials are trying to do more with limited tax dollars, this isn't easy. As such, it has become a necessity for municipalities to supplement their monies with grants and other sources of revenue.

This booklet is intended to give guidance to those seeking grants through the Department of Conservation and Natural Resources (DCNR), Bureau of Recreation and Conservation. It provides general information on what to consider when applying for grants, what steps to take in bringing a potential project to the application stage, tips on preparing the application, and grant administration guidance.

WHAT IS AVAILABLE

DCNR's Bureau of Recreation and Conservation annually awards about \$30 million in planning, acquisition and development grants for parks, recreation, rivers conservation, trails, greenways, and protection of open space and critical natural areas. The application period is in the fall of each year. There are other state and federal programs that offer funding for recreation and conservation projects (See Page 7).

GRANTS - WHAT TO EXPECT!

Receiving a grant to benefit your community is typically good news. However, because it requires work and a commitment by the municipality or non-profit agency, a project coordinator must be designated to apply for the grant and follow the project through its course. The most logical person to fill this role would be a recreation or conservation professional, but such a staff person is not always available in smaller communities and smaller agencies. The manager, director, another staff member, solicitor, planner, board or citizen member, or secretary could assume the role, but the responsible individual should be accessible during business hours.

Grant money can stretch tax dollars and budgets tremendously.

Depending on the grant program, some or all of the cost of a project can be covered by the grant. Most DCNR grant projects require a 50/50 match. If you are successful in administering the grant and completing the project, some grantors will use this factor in providing future grants to your community or agency. You must be patient and realistic about the amount of time needed to complete your project. Grant money administered by government agencies takes time to flow through the system.



Some smaller communities and agencies will not apply for grants because they think there are strings attached. There is a commitment by the grantee to manage, administer, and keep records. Your solicitor or lawyer can review any documents required by the funding body. In most instances the “strings” should not prevent you from taking advantage of the grant money. Because most grant money is from public tax dollars, some requirements include federal and state laws requiring handicapped accessibility, use of the public bidding process, use of wage rates depending on the size of the project, public access, and the ability to maintain the project. None of these items are insurmountable. What’s needed is a planned approach with a conscientious local coordinator who understands his or her responsibility, reads the grant guidelines provided, and keeps in close communication with the grant agency staff.

FIRST STEPS

The Idea/Justification

Discussions with Regional Staff Is DCNR aware of your project? The Bureau of Recreation and Conservation has five regional offices across the state. It is important that you discuss the project with your DCNR regional advisor prior to submitting the application.

Project Definition Reduce the project concept to words. Start with a clear purpose and be sure to state your priorities.

Partnering It is to your advantage to partner with neighboring municipalities, other public agencies, school districts, counties, non-profit organizations and the private sector since grant agencies like cooperative efforts.

Planning Has the project been well conceived? Have you developed a plan or has another entity referred to the project in its plan? Construction projects need a site plan. Discuss the project with local, county, regional planning departments to gain their support. Grants from the Bureau of Recreation and Conservation require applicants to answer questions which address local and county planning and zoning issues.

Surveys Was the need for the project established by surveying public opinion?

Eligibility Determine which grant programs are appropriate for your application. You must also determine the legal applicant for the project.

Need Is the need for the project supported by other individuals and groups?

Timing After considering the grant application deadline, notification of funding, season of the year, determine whether or not you can complete the project in the required amount of time. Grant applications completed or planned at the last minute are less likely to be funded.

Council, Board, or Commission Concurrence Does your governing body embrace the idea or are you surprising them with your project?

Market Trend Information General information and demographics on the people served as a result of the project (basketball players, bird watchers, soccer players, etc.).

Benefits Information noting the recreational, environmental, educational, social, cultural, health, crime reduction, economic benefits and changes that will result from the project.

Filling Out the Application Form

Application Forms Provided by Grantor In most cases, DCNR provides the application form in either a hard copy or electronic form that can be retrieved from the Department's web page. At the present time the Bureau of Recreation and Conservation is not capable of receiving the application form electronically.

Summarize the Project Scope of Work Be clear and concise in describing and answering questions about the project. Use extra space and pages only when necessary to completely describe the project and respond to each question.

Credibility/Capacity Make sure that the project coordinator you select is qualified to apply, administer, and complete the project.

Estimates It is to your benefit to obtain accurate estimates for work. Grantors in most cases know what it costs to do work. Good estimates increase your credibility and make your project budget more realistic.

Budget and Other Sources of Income Financial information is required on all grant application forms. Do your homework and provide realistic budget information. Build flexibility, where practical, into your project scope in case the grant awarded is less than requested.

In Kind/Cash Match Most of the grants from DCNR's Bureau of Recreation and Conservation require a 50% cash or in-kind match approved by the bureau. Using the in-kind match requires good record-keeping that can hold up to an audit.

Pre-Application Workshops

DCNR provides pre-application workshops to assist applicants in the preparation of their application forms. The workshops are particularly important if you are a first-time applicant. Bureau staff will be available to answer your questions.



Checklist

Closing Date Make sure you do not miss the deadline for the grant application submission. Plan your project several months ahead of the deadline so that the grant application can be reviewed and revised as needed.



Address to Send the Application

Double check the address and mail early. Hand deliver the application form if you cannot mail early.

Answer All Criteria You will lose points if you do not address all criteria.

Number of Copies Needed DCNR requires two copies of the application form specified in the announcement.

Supporting Documentation Build your case for funding by providing supporting information. Plans, letters of support, and survey information all help your proposal.

Signatures Make sure the proper official signs the application form.

Timing Ensure the timing of all funding sources is consistent with the project schedule.

ADMINISTERING THE DCNR GRANT

If you are awarded a grant your responsibilities continue until your project has been completed. The project coordinator is responsible for the following items:

Grant Agreement Your solicitor or lawyer should review the terms and conditions of the grant agreement before signing. Make sure an authorized person signs the signature page of the agreement or it will be returned to you, delaying the project. The Bureau of Recreation and Conservation has streamlined the process by making the signature page for the grant application also the signature page for the agreement.

Post Award Consultations DCNR requires grant recipients to attend these consultations. The fully-executed agreement and other details of how to complete the project are covered at that time.

Request for Payments DCNR can make some payments in advance if you submit the proper documentation. Payments will take 6-8 weeks to process.

ADMINISTERING THE DCNR GRANT Cont.

Contacting Grants Project Management Division for Information

The Grants Project Management Division of DCNR will assign a Project Manager once a grant has been awarded. Call (717) 783-4734 for more information.

Final Inspection and Payment Once the project is completed, notify your regional advisor for a final inspection of the project. A request for final payment can then be issued with payment made in about 6-8 weeks.

Other Sources of Information

The Pennsylvania State Association of Boroughs (PSAB) conducts grant writing and grant management courses intended for municipal employees who must write or review proposals for federal and state grants. For additional information call 1-800-232-7722.

The Pennsylvania State Association of Township Supervisors (PSATS) provides some training in grants writing. (717) 763-0930

County Conservation Districts - These districts can also be helpful with grant writing.

Websites - grantwriters.com and The Grantsmanship Center, www.tgci.com, can provide you with other information on how to submit grants. The Center for Rural Pa. allows access to more than 350 sources of information on state, federal and non-profit grants through the New Pa. Rural Access Guide Website: www.ruralpa.org.

County Planning Departments Sometimes these agencies will provide grant assistance.

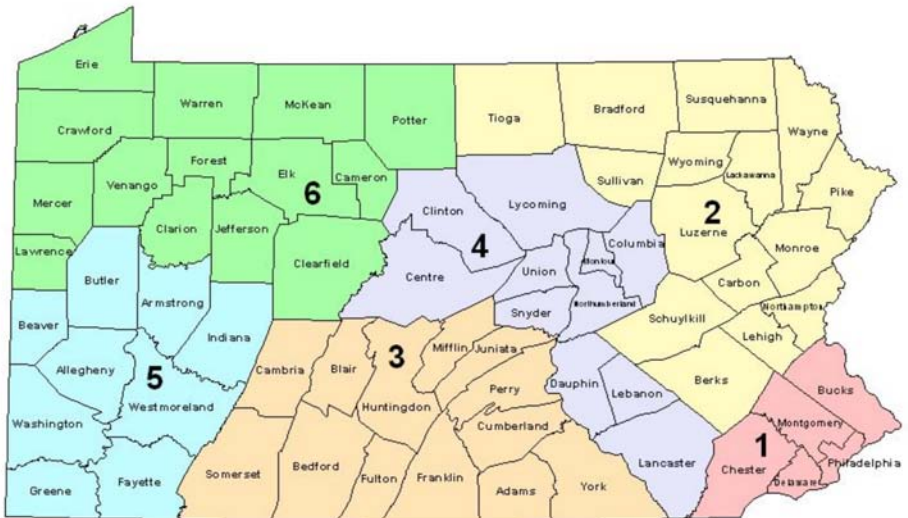


Other Sources of Information (Cont.)

Penn State Cooperative Extension Service Community Development Agent, Walt Whitmer, has developed a grant brochure and conducts grant training workshops. (717) 436-7744

DCNR, Bureau of Recreation and Conservation Regional Advisors

There are five regional offices across the state that can assist you before and during the application process. The map below shows the regional delineations.



Region 1 Southeast Regional Office (215) 644-0609

Region 2 Northeast Regional Office (570) 963-4157

Regions 3&4 Southcentral/Northcentral Regional Office (717) 772-3839

Region 5 Southwest Regional Office (412) 880-0486

Region 6 Northwest Regional Office (814) 871-4190



QUESTIONNAIRE

Please fill out this page, detach or photo copy, and mail to
the Department of Conservation and Natural Resources
Bureau of Recreation and Conservation
Rachel Carson State Office Building
P.O. Box 8475
Harrisburg, Pa. 17105-8475
(If you need more space attach an additional page)

Did you find this grants booklet helpful and informative?
Why or why not?

Which sections were most helpful? The least?

What questions or concerns do you have regarding the
grant application process?

What suggestions do you have for the next edition of this
booklet?

Other comments and suggestions:







Edward G. Rendell, Governor
Michael DiBerardinis, Secretary

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